

Turning to rock

Over time, the minerals that make up the remains of an animal will be completely or partially replaced by rock minerals. It is now a fossil.

Digging it up

Paleontologists use tools such as hammers and pickaxes, and even dental tools and paintbrushes, to uncover and clean a fossil.

See also

Find out more about how rocks erode in the rock cycle (24–25), and read more about dinosaurs (96–101).

Fossils are found in sedimentary rocks, such as limestone, sandstone, or mudstone, all formed by the gathering of sediment.

Erosion of the overlying rock may expose part of the fossil.

Paleontologists add plaster jackets, like the cast you get when you break a bone, to protect the fossils.

Amber This special type of fossil is formed from resin in trees. Insects and other small animals trapped in this sticky substance are perfectly preserved when it hardens.



Trace fossils Types of trace fossils include footprints, burrows, and coprolites. They can tell us more about how an animal lived and behaved than body fossils such as bones and shells.

